

RESEARCH APPROACH

5 stakeholder interviews were conducted during this simulation (approximately 15 minutes each). The model answers below represent the findings a well-prepared participant group should be able to surface.

Personas interviewed:

- Aunt Mary Tan — Cashier
- Uncle John DeSouza — Owner / Founder
- Mrs Selva — Loyal Customer
- Jacky — HDB Staff / Bulk Buyer
- Darren DeSouza — Main Barista

Method:

- Semi-structured conversation
- AI-simulated personas (case brief)
- Focus: pain points, workarounds, aspirations
- ~15 minutes per persona

BUSINESS SNAPSHOT

Tea Fellas is a family-run bubble tea and milk tea shop in Toa Payoh, Singapore, founded in 2008 by John DeSouza after corporate retrenchment. Operating Monday to Friday only, the shop serves around 250 customers daily — HDB residents, office workers, and morning commuters. The business is entirely paper-based with no digital technology; processes run on handwritten chits, personal memory, and paper stamp cards. Despite its loyal customer base and a signature drink (Brown Sugar Pearl Milk Tea), Tea Fellas is constrained by thin margins and operational friction that prevents it from scaling.

250 /day

Daily customers (Mon–Fri)

\$27,500

Monthly revenue

\$4,100

Net monthly surplus

KEY THEMES

Four overarching themes emerged consistently across all 5 interviews:

Theme 1: Ordering & Queue Friction

All customer personas experience significant queue friction — 15-30 minutes during peak hours — with no pre-ordering option available. Even arriving early (like Jacky at 7:15am) does not eliminate waiting.

Theme 2: Order Accuracy

From handwritten chit to kitchen to collection, the paper-based flow introduces errors at every handoff. Mary's handwriting, Salmiah's manual re-keying, and John's memory all contribute to an estimated 15% error rate.

Theme 3: Loyalty & Retention

Mrs Selva's 17-year loyalty is at genuine risk from lost stamp cards and queue frustration. Regular customers already use digital loyalty apps (Kopitiam) and expect the same from Tea Fellas.

Theme 4: Operational Scalability

The current manual process is strained at a single location. Both Darren and John see a second outlet as the business dream, but the consensus is clear: fix operations before expanding, or risk chaos at scale.

M

Aunty Mary Tan
Cashier · John's wife, late 50s · Handles payments and all handwritten order chits

TOP PAIN POINT
Under peak-hour pressure, her handwritten chits become unclear. She knows this causes order errors downstream for Darren and ultimately for customers, but has no practical solution without a digital tool.

HER ASPIRATION
A tablet or digital input system she can learn to use. Wants to lighten the burden of managing lost loyalty card complaints, which are a daily annoyance she manages manually.

"If got tablet, I can try. As long as someone shows me."

J

Uncle John DeSouza
Owner / Founder · Early 60s · Manages collection counter entirely from memory

TOP PAIN POINT
Drink mix-ups at collection — wrong drinks handed to wrong customers — and the inability to notify waiting customers. He shouts names across a noisy shop and still sometimes gets it wrong.

HIS ASPIRATION
A proper ticket and notification system for the existing shop, and eventually a second outlet for Darren to manage independently so John can step back from day-to-day operations.

"I know everyone's face, but when the drinks pile up, sometimes I make mistakes. The young people today, they want things faster."

S

Mrs Selva
Loyal Customer · Early 50s · 3-4 visits/week, 17-year regular

TOP PAIN POINT
Has been late to work because of the peak-hour queue. Has missed at least 4 free drinks due to lost stamp cards. Feels the queue is too long for a single drink, especially compared to digital alternatives nearby.

HER ASPIRATION
A mobile app or QR ordering flow like the Kopitiam app — so she can order ahead, earn loyalty rewards digitally, and know when her drink is ready without hovering at the counter.

"I use Kopitiam app already, so easy. Why not Tea Fellas?"

K

Jacky
HDB Senior Manager · 35 · Orders 5-6 drinks for his team daily, arrives 7:15am

TOP PAIN POINT
Arrives at 7:15am to beat the queue and still waits 15 minutes. Ordering 5-6 drinks verbally is error-prone, and collecting without clear per-person labels means he regularly hands the wrong drink to teammates.

HIS ASPIRATION
A web ordering link or QR code that lets him pre-order and pay for his team's drinks from his phone, with each drink clearly labelled by team member name for easy distribution.

"If I could just send a link to the team, everyone orders their own. No mistakes, no waiting. Just pick up and go."

D

Darren DeSouza
Main Barista · 25 · SMU Business grad, John's nephew, makes every single drink alone

TOP PAIN POINT
Unclear chits force him to stop mid-drink-preparation to clarify with Mary — a brief but disruptive interruption during peak hours. He cannot build a reliable rhythm without a clear, consistent source of order information.

HIS ASPIRATION
Digital operations (kitchen display, clear orders) first, then a second outlet to manage independently. He has already researched solutions and drafted a proposal for Uncle John.

"Fix the operations first. A second outlet with the current process would just be chaos times two."

PAIN POINT SUMMARY

#	Pain Point	Who Feels It	Severity	Frequency
1	Handwritten chits cause order errors	Mary, Darren, Customers	High	Daily
2	Long queue — no pre-ordering	Mrs Selva, Jacky, Customers	High	Every peak
3	Memory-based collection → wrong drinks	John, Customers	High	Daily
4	No customer notification system	John, Customers	Medium	Every peak
5	Paper loyalty stamp cards — lost/forgotten	Mary, Mrs Selva	Medium	Regular
6	Bulk order confusion and mislabelling	Jacky	Medium	Daily
7	Single barista bottleneck (Darren alone)	Darren	High	Every peak
8	No feedback mechanism	John	Medium	Ongoing
9	Supply chain won't scale to second outlet	John, Darren	High	Structural

EMERGING OPPORTUNITY AREAS

1. Digitise the Order Journey

From cashier to barista to collection, the order flow is entirely paper-based and dependent on human memory. Introducing a digital ordering layer — QR code, kitchen display, and ticket-based collection — would remove the three biggest sources of errors across the chain in a single intervention.

2. Delight Customers with Speed and Recognition

Pre-ordering, digital loyalty, and collection notifications are all within reach of affordable off-the-shelf solutions. These directly address the frustrations of Tea Fellas' most loyal customers (Mrs Selva) and highest-value buyers (Jacky) — customers who are already using digital alternatives and comparing.

3. Prepare for Sustainable Growth

Darren and John both see a second outlet as the business dream. But the current manual processes cannot scale — a second outlet would simply duplicate the chaos. Fixing operations digitally now is the prerequisite for responsible expansion later. Note: the supply chain (Pain Point #9 — how John orders from Lim Teck Seng Trading) is a structural gap that A1 alone does not address. Fully resolving it requires the A2 integrated digital solution. C1 accepts this as a conscious Year 2 trade-off.

→ NEXT STEP — PHASE 2: DEFINE

Your team has completed the research phase. In Phase 2 (Define), you will frame the core problem, define the product vision, and identify where Business Process Re-engineering opportunities lie. Use these findings as your evidence base.